



Super Constellation

The Lockheed L-1049 Super Constellation represented the zenith of piston-powered airliner development. Launched in response to rival Douglas Aircraft stretching its DC-6, the Super Constellation featured a distinctive triple-tail fin. Powered by four of the largest piston engines ever made, it was popular with both airlines and the military. However, its introduction in 1951 preceded the first jets by only a few years, and production ceased in 1958.

LOCKHEED DEVELOPED the L-1049 Super Constellation from its earlier L-049 Constellation. It was a very successful aircraft, and although Lockheed began to consider stretching it almost as soon as it flew, the idea was shelved due to a lack of suitable engines. However, when it became apparent that the stretched DC-6B would be able to carry 23 more passengers than a production Constellation, Lockheed launched the Super Constellation. More than 16 ft (5 m) longer than the

Constellation, it cruised 27 mph (44km/h) faster, could carry 33,000 lb (15,000 kg) more, and had a superior range. It was powered by four Wright R-3350-972s—sophisticated 18-cylinder twin-row radial—which could produce up to 3,250 hp each. Unfortunately, the engine's complexity had an adverse affect on the reliability and maintenance of the Super Constellation, and once the first American jetliners entered service, the Super Constellation was soon phased out by the major airlines.



FRONT VIEW

